

# Zerado – Voice & Tone Working Guide

The full standard is `brand-manual.md` §8. This is the pocket version, with the situations that actually came up while writing the landing page.

## The three words, and what they are not

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| We are                                      | We are not              |
|---------------------------------------------|-------------------------|
| <b>Dry</b> — the fact is the point          | Sarcastic, or bubbly    |
| <b>Concrete</b> — numbers, names, specifics | Vague, or jargon-padded |
| <b>Confident</b> — direct, no hedging       | Boastful, or timid      |

The audience is people who live in a terminal. They have a finely-tuned detector for marketing language, they will forgive niche, and they will not forgive hype.

## Do / don't, drawn from real Zerado situations

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### 1 • Describing what the product does

- ✗ "Experience the power of a next-generation, blazing-fast CLI-first gaming ecosystem."
- ✓ "It's a text program. It starts instantly, works offline, and your library is one file you own."
- Three verifiable claims beat six adjectives. This audience checks.

### 2 • A price is in budget but above its historical low

- ✗ "🔥 This game is a STEAL at \$15! Grab it before it's gone!"
- ✓ "\$15, and in budget. It's been \$8. Maybe wait."
- Zerado's actual value proposition here is telling you *not* to buy. Fake urgency destroys the trust the whole feature depends on.

### **3 • Marking a game finished**

- ✗ "Congratulations on this incredible achievement! You're a true champion!"
- ✓ "Zerado. 41 hours. Sixth this year."
- The moment carries itself. Three facts land harder than an exclamation mark.

### **4 • Nothing is downloadable yet (the whole page is pre-launch)**

- ✗ "Try Zerado today — download now!"
- ✓ "Nothing to install yet. Tell us you're in, and we'll tell you when there is."
- Say what stage the product is actually at. A waitlist framed honestly reads as early, not as broken.

### **5 • The community layer costs money later**

- ✗ "We're SO excited to announce our amazing new social features — coming soon!"
- ✓ "These run on servers, and servers cost money — so this part will be supported by donation or a donation once it exists."
- State the cost before anyone asks. Up front reads as respect; discovered later reads as a catch. And disclosure is not an ask — never follow this sentence with a button.

### **6 • Steam needs a public profile, and that's a real limitation**

- ✗ "Oops! Something went wrong. Please try again later."
- ✓ "Steam only returns a library if the profile is public, or if the key belongs to that same account. If a profile is private, Steam won't share the list — that's a Steam setting, not something Zerado can work around."
- Name what happened, why, and whether it's on us or the reader. "Something went wrong" is the one sentence this audience cannot act on.

### **7 • A feature that isn't built yet**

- ✗ "Powerful recommendations, coming soon!"

- ✓ "Phase 3 — Recommendations & Budget. What to buy, and whether to wait. Planned."
- The roadmap format *is* the honesty mechanism. A phase name, a plain-language line, and a status marker that never says "done" until it is.

## 8 • Introducing a Portuguese word

- ✗ Leaving *zerado* or *sinopse* unglossed, assuming the reader will infer it.
- ✗ Explaining it more than once — a glossary makes the page read like homework.
- ✓ One clause, at the first appearance, then used plainly ever after: "*zerado* — Portuguese for beaten: finished, cleared, 100%'d."

## Words this brand never uses

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Banned outright, no exceptions found while writing this page:

- **Hype adjectives:** revolutionary, seamless, unleash, game-changing, next-generation, cutting-edge, blazing-fast, powerful (as a standalone claim), amazing, incredible.
- **Exclamation marks.** No situation in this product needs one — not a sync, not a purchase verdict, not a *zerado*.
- **Emoji in product copy.** State is carried by colour + glyph + label (brand-manual §4.3); emoji carry nothing and undercut that system.
- **"Gamer."** Never used to describe the reader.
- **Filler openers:** "In today's fast-paced world," "As we all know," "It's no secret that," "Now more than ever." Every one wastes the most valuable line on the page.
- **Vague quantities.** "A lot of hours," "tons of games," "many players." Say the number, or cut the claim.
- **Thesaurus-inflation.** "Utilize" for use, "leverage" for use, "empower" for help. Plain verbs read as more confident, not less.

# The three awkward moments this page has to hold, and how

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**1 • Nothing to download yet.** Say the stage plainly and once, then move on — don't apologise for it repeatedly, and don't bury it. "Nothing to install yet" is a complete sentence; it doesn't need "unfortunately" in front of it or "but soon!" after it.

**2 • The community costs money, eventually.** State the cost before it's asked. Never attach a button, a price, or a tier name to the statement — there isn't one yet, and inventing one to look more finished is worse than saying "not decided."

**3 • Steam needs a public profile.** This is a real limitation of a third-party service, not a Zerado bug, and the copy says so directly: name what's required, name why, and stop. Don't soften it with "unfortunately" or oversell the workaround, because there isn't one.

## One test that catches most drafts before they ship

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Read the sentence back and ask: **could a competitor's marketing team have written this exact sentence?** If yes, it's generic — cut it or replace the adjective with a fact. Every sentence on this page that survived that test is the one doing real work.

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|-------------------------------|---------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
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